

down. Really, I reread my book and saw nothing to add to the text, nothing we had not already encountered at some point in history, like the earlier debacles, nothing I had learned from. Alas, nothing.

The corollary is obvious: since there is nothing new about the crisis of 2008, we will not learn from it and we will make the same mistake in the future. And the evidence is there at the time of writing: the IMF continues to issue forecasts (not realizing that previous ones did not work and that the poor suckers relying on them are—once again—going to get in trouble); economics professors still use the Gaussian; the current administration is populated with those who are bringing model error into industrial proportion, making us rely on models even more than ever before.*

But the crisis provides an illustration for the need for robustness, worth discussing here.

Over the past twenty-five hundred years of recorded ideas, only fools and Platonists (or, worse, the species called central bankers) have believed in engineered utopias. We will see in the section on the Fourth Quadrant that the idea is not to correct mistakes and eliminate randomness from social and economic life through monetary policy, subsidies, and so on. *The idea is simply to let human mistakes and miscalculations remain confined*, and to prevent their spreading through the system, as Mother Nature does. Reducing volatility and ordinary randomness increases exposure to Black Swans—it creates an artificial quiet.

My dream is to have a true Epistemocracy—that is, a society robust to expert errors, forecasting errors, and hubris, one that can be resistant to the incompetence of politicians, regulators, economists, central bankers, bankers, policy wonks, and epidemiologists. We cannot make economists more scientific; we cannot make humans more rational (whatever that means); we cannot make fads disappear. The solution is somewhat simple, once we isolate harmful errors, as we will see with the Fourth Quadrant.

So I am currently torn between (a) my desire to spend time mulling my ideas in European cafés and in the tranquility of my study, or looking for someone who can have a conversation while walking slowly in a nice urban setting, and (b) the feeling of obligation to engage in activism to robustify society, by talking to uninteresting people and being immersed in the cacophony of the unaesthetic journalistic and media world, going to Washington to watch phonies in suits walking around the streets, having to defend my ideas while making an effort to be smooth and hide